

A number of reasons have been blamed for the failure of WAP to offer what it promised. A large number of critics point towards the WML language, which cut users off from the true HTML Web, leaving only native WAP content and Web-to-WAP content available to WAP users. However, others argue that technology at that stage would simply not have been able to give access to anything but custom-designed content.

Another argument is that under-specification of terminal requirements. In the early WAP standards, there were many optional features and under-specified requirements, which meant that compliant devices would not necessarily interoperate properly. This resulted in great variability in phones' actual behaviour. As an example, some phone models would not accept a page more than 1 KB in size; others would just simply crash. The user interface of devices was also under specified

Constrained user interface capabilities were also touted as a reason for the failure of the protocol. Terminals with small black and white screens and few buttons, as the early WAP terminals were, are not very apt at presenting a lot of information to their user, which compounded the other problems: one would have had to be extra careful in designing the user interface on such a resource-constrained device.

These problems might have been alleviated by a WML authoring tool that would have allowed content providers to easily publish content that would interoperate flawlessly with many models, adapting the pages presented to the User-Agent type. However, while some development kits existed, it was no such "magic software." Developing for the Web was easy: with a text editor and a Web browser, anybody could get started, in comparison, the stringent requirements of the WML specifications, the variability in terminals and the time involved in testing on wireless terminals was considerably lengthened by the lack of widely available desktop authoring and emulation tools.